

Rival Restaurant

Named story series: Manager command posts, live operations, and strategic agency

Purpose. Define the player character as the restaurant’s manager-owner: a visible operator who personally intervenes on the floor while making strategic decisions from three physical command posts.

The manager must make decisions that are spatially embodied, server-authoritative, easy to read, and meaningfully competitive. The player cannot optimize every part of the restaurant simultaneously: creating demand at the door can overwhelm service; adding service capacity can reduce net profit; protecting inventory may cost cash that could have funded an upgrade or promotion.

Manager command model

Command post	Manager responsibility	Core actions	Primary trade-off
Maitre d' stand	Acquire, convert, queue, seat, and recover guests.	Timed specials; guest policy; street attraction; seating investments.	More demand can overload the dining room and kitchen.
Service station	Staff, pace, and recover dining-room service.	Hire relief staff; select service priority; buy room-flow bonuses.	Labor improves execution but directly reduces profit.
Pantry & expedite board	Protect menu availability and direct production.	Read stock; order replenishment; react to market prices; select kitchen focus.	Fast stock is expensive; overbuying consumes cash and risks waste.

Core loop

Observe an event, queue, shortage, or dining-room failure → walk to the relevant command post → make one clear, bounded decision → return to the active floor and personally cover the highest-priority task → reassess. The manager is an owner-operator, not an all-knowing remote dashboard.

Story roadmap

Build order	Story name	What it establishes
1	The Maitre d' Playbook	Live front-door strategy and the first timed specials.
2	The Pantry Is Open	Service-phase inventory visibility, purchasing, and event-linked market costs.
3	The Service Station	Temporary dining-room labor with real payroll and service priorities.
4	The Maitre d' Advantage	Seating, street-attraction, and guest-recovery upgrade paths.
5	The Kitchen Command Board	Production priorities and menu protection at the expedite pass.
6	The Manager's Ledger	HUD synthesis, telemetry, and post-match explanations of decisions.

The Maitre d' Playbook

Front-door strategy, timed specials, and guest flow control

Story intent

- Give the manager a physical strategic post at the restaurant entrance.
- Allow clear, event-responsive choices that affect customer consideration, seating, queue resilience, and conversion.
- Prove that live strategy can matter during service without exposing a mid-match spreadsheet of arbitrary prices.

What ships

Element	Definition
Maitre d' stand	An in-world stand near the street entry with a clear interaction range and contextual prompt.
Front Door board	A compact React panel showing queue condition, open tables, wait condition, current event, active special, and rival queue state.
One active front-door policy	Initially, the player can run one special/policy at a time, making the choice legible and preventing stacked buffs.
Timed, data-driven effects	All costs, durations, cooldowns, eligibility, and effects live in shared data/tuning, never inline client logic.

Initial catalog

Option	Best use	Benefit	Trade-off
Lunch Express	Office rush / fast menu	Improves appeal for quick, value-conscious guests.	Lower average check or tip potential.
Happy Hour	Nightlife / price-sensitive wave	Improves value conversion and drinks/add-ons.	Lower margin; higher order volume.
Half-Price Wine	Pre-theater couples	Improves premium-couple conversion and attachment.	Reduced beverage profit; poor lunch fit.
Game-Day Combo	Stadium groups	Improves group conversion for hearty/shareable menu tags.	Raises table and server pressure.
Chef's Feature	Strong dish/event match	Promotes one available, high-fit dish.	Can intensify station load and consume scarce stock.
Waitlist Honesty	Long queue	Protects satisfaction and reduces late abandonment.	May lower immediate conversion.

Player flow

1. Approach the stand and press the contextual interaction key.
2. Read only qualitative operational signals: busy/quiet street, short/long wait, open tables, current event, and active special.

3. Choose a policy, pay the stated cost if any, and begin its duration/cooldown.
4. Return to the restaurant floor; the effect is visible through customer behavior, queue state, and HUD/world indicators.

Acceptance criteria

- An in-world Maitre d' stand has a clear interaction prompt and range.
- The panel shows live queue, capacity, qualitative wait condition, event context, current policy, and tactical options.
- The first version permits exactly one active special/policy.
- Every special has explicit benefit, downside, duration, eligibility, and cost/cooldown.
- All customer-choice outcomes remain probabilistic and server-authoritative.
- No arbitrary per-dish price editing during service in this story.
- Active policy state appears in the HUD, world, and front-door board.
- A standalone harness previews each policy under customer-wave and event fixtures.

The Pantry Is Open

Live inventory visibility, restocking, and event-driven market price movement

Story intent

- Give the manager clear service-phase control over inventory that is currently configured only during setup.
- Replace blind shortages with a physical pantry decision point, visible risk, and recoverable purchasing choices.
- Tie market-price movement to seeded public events and understandable district causes rather than noise.

What ships

Element	Definition
Pantry / stockroom terminal	An in-world command point beside inventory storage with a clear interaction prompt.
Pantry board	Live ingredient counts, qualitative risk, affected dishes, blocked tickets, price direction, and restock arrival state.
Restock order system	Standard, emergency, bulk, and priority options with different cost/time trade-offs.
Market explanation strip	Plain-language reasons for cost/delivery changes, such as "Supplier shortage: lettuce +60%."

Initial catalog

Option	Best use	Benefit	Trade-off
Standard supplier run	Current market price	Medium delivery time; normal quantity.	Planned replenishment.
Emergency runner	Price premium	Fast delivery; smaller quantity.	Protect one critical menu item during a rush.
Bulk delivery	Lower unit price / high total spend	Slow delivery; larger quantity.	Prepare for a forecasted wave.
Priority restock	Normal or slight premium	Preferred supplier queue position.	Protect a high-value or promoted dish.

Player flow

1. Walk to the pantry and open the board.
2. See current stock and qualitative headline states such as STOCKED, WATCH, AT RISK, BLOCKING, EXPENSIVE, or DEAL.
3. See the dishes affected and how many likely orders remain before risk.
4. Choose the replenishment method, accepting its cash, time, and quantity trade-off.
5. Return to the floor while delivery progress and new stock remain visible in the HUD and pantry world view.

Acceptance criteria

- The pantry panel covers every ingredient used by the active menu.
- It shows count, qualitative risk, affected dishes, blocked-ticket impact, price direction, and causal explanation for material market movement.
- Market costs and delivery conditions are deterministic from match seed and event state, and public/fair to both players.
- The player can place standard, emergency, and bulk restock orders during service.
- Cash, availability, phase, stock rules, and order constraints validate server-side.
- Emergency replenishment is materially faster and materially more expensive than planned replenishment.
- A shortage alert identifies both the missing ingredient and impacted dishes.
- Inventory cost, stock orders, and shortages are recorded for results and telemetry.
- The current automatic-restock abstraction is removed, disabled, or explicitly narrowed when manual live purchasing ships.
- A harness covers low stock, active shortage, price spike, emergency order, bulk order, and delivery delay.

The Service Station

Dining-room staffing, floor priorities, and payroll pressure

Story intent

- Turn the dining room into a manager-controlled capacity decision instead of a passive server simulation.
- Let the manager buy labor when the room is the bottleneck, while making the effect on net profit impossible to ignore.
- Keep staffing tactical and match-scoped—no deep HR simulation in the first iteration.

What ships

Element	Definition
Service station	An in-world waiter support station near the dining room and service pass.
Dining Room board	Live occupancy, dirty/open tables, ready-food backlog, server workload, satisfaction risk, and payroll burn.
Temporary contracts	Match-scoped relief staff with a hire fee, recurring wages, arrival delay, and commitment/duration.
Service priority	One current team directive: ready food, turnover, guest recovery, or balanced service.

Initial catalog

Option	Best use	Benefit	Trade-off
Relief Server	Deliver, take orders, seat when needed	Reduces ready-food delay and table wait.	Payroll; may idle if kitchen is the bottleneck.
Busser	Clear/reset tables and assist front-of-house support	Improves turnover and reduces dirty-table blockage.	Payroll; little value in low occupancy.
Dining Captain	Policy mode, not a new body initially	Focuses existing staff on delivery, turnover, or recovery.	Neglects other room priorities.
Expediter	Later role/unlock	Improves pass-to-floor handoff.	Must not erase the value of owner delivery.

Player flow

1. Walk to the service station and inspect demand/capacity.
2. Hire a role, pay a one-time hire fee, then accept recurring wage burn.
3. Wait for the staff member's arrival/onboarding delay.
4. Select one room priority based on current operational need.
5. Release or let the contract expire under a clear commitment rule; no exploitative instant toggling or refund loop.

Acceptance criteria

- A service station has a clear in-world interaction prompt.
- The board shows live occupancy, open/dirty tables, ready-food backlog, worker load, satisfaction risk, and payroll burn.
- The manager can hire at least a Relief Server and a Busser through server-authoritative actions.
- Each temporary hire has data-defined hire fee, recurring wage interval, arrival delay, maximum count, duration/commitment, and role-specific priorities.
- Labor costs deduct server-side and appear separately from revenue in net-profit/results data.
- Extra labor improves relevant tasks but does not resolve unrelated kitchen or stock bottlenecks.
- A single dining-room priority can be selected at a time.
- New staff visibly enter/occupy an assignment, show a role icon, and produce a clear arcade confirmation.
- A service-station harness demonstrates understaffed, balanced, and overstaffed cases.

The Maitre d' Advantage

Front-door upgrades for seating speed, attraction, and guest recovery

Story intent

- Turn the Maitre d' stand from a one-off special menu into a long-term strategic investment path.
- Create front-door upgrades that matter only when acquisition, queueing, or guest recovery is the limiting factor.
- Ensure that every purchase has a visible restaurant change and server-authoritative outcome.

What ships

Element	Definition	
Host Stand Toolkit	Seating throughput	Reduce
Street Chalkboard	Street attraction	Raises
Queue Pager System	Queue resilience	Slows
Guest Recovery Kit	Recovery capability	Unlock
Maitre d' Radio	Coordination	Improv
Window Display	Special amplification	Streng

Player flow

1. Approach the Maitre d' stand or dedicated front-door purchase point.
2. Review data-driven upgrades that are currently affordable and applicable.
3. Purchase after authoritative validation of cash, prerequisite tier, ownership, and interaction range.
4. See a physical change: signs, queue ropes, tablets, pager rack, radio, display, or greeter elements.
5. Observe the effect in the correct operational layer—not as an unexplained global stat increase.

Acceptance criteria

- All Maitre d' upgrades are represented in shared upgrade data.
- Purchase validates server-side for cash, range, tier prerequisite, ownership, phase, and implementation status.
- No upgrade category exceeds three tiers.
- Seating upgrades change seating behavior only when seating is actually constraining acquisition.
- Attraction upgrades affect consideration, not guaranteed customer choice.
- Queue-protection upgrades affect explainable wait/abandonment behavior.
- Every upgrade has a visible in-world change.
- Upgrade effects surface in HUD, tactical overview, and post-match explanation.

- An upgrade-preview harness compares host stand, street signage, queue behavior, and attraction states.

The Kitchen Command Board

Expedite priorities, menu protection, and strategic kitchen direction

Story intent

- Make the kitchen a manager-directed operation without asking the player to micromanage every worker.
- Place production strategy at the expediter's pass, where ready food, ticket urgency, and dining-room handoff meet.
- Allow one clear kitchen focus with a visible benefit and a meaningful opportunity cost.

What ships

Element	Definition
Expedite / pass board	In-world command surface located at the service pass.
Kitchen overview	Station queues, ready-food age, shortages, menu availability, and event/special pressure.
One active kitchen focus	A data-defined worker-priority bias, not a simulation override.
Visible worker intent	Worker roles/current jobs reveal how the chosen mode affects action selection.

Initial catalog

Option	Best use	Benefit	Trade-off
Rush the Pass	Prioritize near-ready tickets and handoff.	Clear ready-food/freshness pressure.	New tickets can wait longer.
Protect the Special	Favor event/promotion dish tickets.	Exploit a short opportunity window.	Other dishes can fall behind.
Clear the Queue	Favor shorter or constrained tickets.	Recover station backlog.	May delay premium/high-value tickets.
Save Ingredients	Avoid/deprioritize scarce ingredients.	Protect menu availability.	Lower conversion and fewer menu choices.
Premium First	Favor critic/VIP/high-margin tickets.	Win high-value outcomes.	Can damage broad throughput.
Recovery Mode	Favor oldest patience-risk tables.	Prevent guest loss.	Less immediate production efficiency.

Player flow

1. Walk to the expedite pass and inspect actual kitchen pressure.
2. Choose one active focus based on queue, shortage, event, special, and patience context.

3. Observe worker task changes and queue movement in the world.
4. Personally intervene where the policy cannot solve the current bottleneck.
5. Switching focus has a cooldown or commitment cost so it cannot be spammed every snapshot.

Acceptance criteria

- The expedite/pass area exposes a kitchen-command interaction.
- The panel shows queues, ready-food age, shortages, menu availability, and active special/event demand.
- Only one server-authoritative kitchen priority is active initially.
- Every mode has a benefit and explicit opportunity cost.
- Worker priorities remain explainable through visible task/current-job state and telemetry.
- A policy cannot bypass inventory, station-failure, carry, range, or validation rules.
- Current kitchen focus is visible in HUD, tactical overview, and at the pass.
- Recommendations use qualitative language, not exposed utility math.
- A kitchen harness compares the same ticket mix under every mode.

The Manager's Ledger

Management-state synthesis, telemetry, and decision explanations

Story intent

- Connect the Maitre d', dining-room, pantry, and kitchen decisions into one coherent management identity.
- Make active choices visible without cluttering the HUD.
- Explain at match end whether a decision created value, merely shifted the bottleneck, or cost more than it returned.

What ships

Element	Definition
Compact management chips	Front door, dining, kitchen, and pantry status shown as concise HUD/tactical overview state.
Decision telemetry	Records specials, staffing contracts, payroll, restocks, market premiums, kitchen modes, and resulting outcomes.
Results narrative	Generates explanations from actual tracked decisions and causal outcomes, never fabricated copy.
Constraint diagnosis	Classifies the match's dominant limitation: demand, seating/service, production, inventory, or prioritization.

Player flow

1. During service, show compact active-policy chips rather than permanent management panels.
2. On Tab/tactical overview, summarize all three command posts together.
3. At match completion, build explanations only from tracked events, costs, decisions, and outcomes.
4. Use results feedback to teach what decision should change in a rematch.

Acceptance criteria

- HUD state shows active front-door special, staffing/payroll state, kitchen focus, and pantry risk compactly.
- Tactical overview combines demand, capacity, kitchen, and inventory constraints.
- Results report special performance, incremental labor expense, restock expense, inventory/market premium, and key trade-offs.
- Narrative insights are backed by recorded decision and outcome data.
- Telemetry supports determining whether the limiting factor was demand conversion, seating/service capacity, production capacity, inventory availability, or prioritization.
- No results copy claims a causal outcome that was not observed/tracked.

Implementation guardrails

Keep the stories strategically rich without making the MVP opaque or unbounded.

Authority and architecture

- The client sends intent. The server validates and applies all cash, pricing, staffing, inventory, customer-choice, upgrade, and score outcomes.
- New gameplay behavior belongs in registered server systems, not in match.js. System registration order remains an explicit contract.
- React owns command-post panels, HUD chips, results explanations, and accessibility overlays. Three.js owns the physical command posts, staff, stock, queue, and world-state visuals.
- Rules emit published state; scene/UI views render it. Harnesses must be able to mount and inspect the same visual components with mocked state.
- All balance content—specials, staffing contracts, restock products, market modifiers, kitchen policies, upgrade tiers—belongs in shared data. Tunable values belong in the shared tuning module.
- Use seeded event/market state and named RNG streams so the same seed and inputs reproduce price movement, demand, and restock conditions.

Scope controls

- Begin with one active special, two temporary dining-room contracts, three replenishment options, and one kitchen-priority mode at a time.
- Do not create unrestricted mid-service menu editing. Named specials are clearer, easier to balance, and easier to explain.
- Do not turn temporary staff into persistent characters, traits, schedules, or hiring trees in this series.
- Do not let a promotion, staffing hire, or kitchen policy become a universal benefit. Each must have a visible cost or displaced priority.
- Preserve probabilistic customer choice; attraction can improve consideration but cannot force customers to enter.
- Reuse existing alert priority/capping behavior. New management states should create actionable feedback, not a flood of alerts.

Measurement plan

Decision	Minimum measurement
Specials	Activation count, applicable customer waves, conversion delta, average-check delta, queue/satisfaction impact.
Staff contracts	Hire cost, wages paid, task completions, ready-food age reduction, guests served delta, net-profit delta.
Restocking	Stockout duration, blocked tickets, emergency premium paid, order arrival time, wasted/unused stock if modeled.
Kitchen modes	Queue depth change, freshness losses avoided, delayed orders, priority-ticket outcomes, guest-loss impact.
Upgrades	Purchase time, applicable bottleneck, visible effect, incremental outcome, payback/strategic value.

Definition of success

A new player can explain, during a rush, what their manager is currently trying to accomplish at the front door, in the dining room, and in the kitchen; can name the cost of that decision; and can see why the restaurant succeeded or failed afterward.